



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

Public Speaking

Lecture 06: Relevance of Public Speaking

Prof. Binod Mishra

DEPARTMENT OF HUMANITIES AND SOCIAL SCIENCES



Relevance Theory

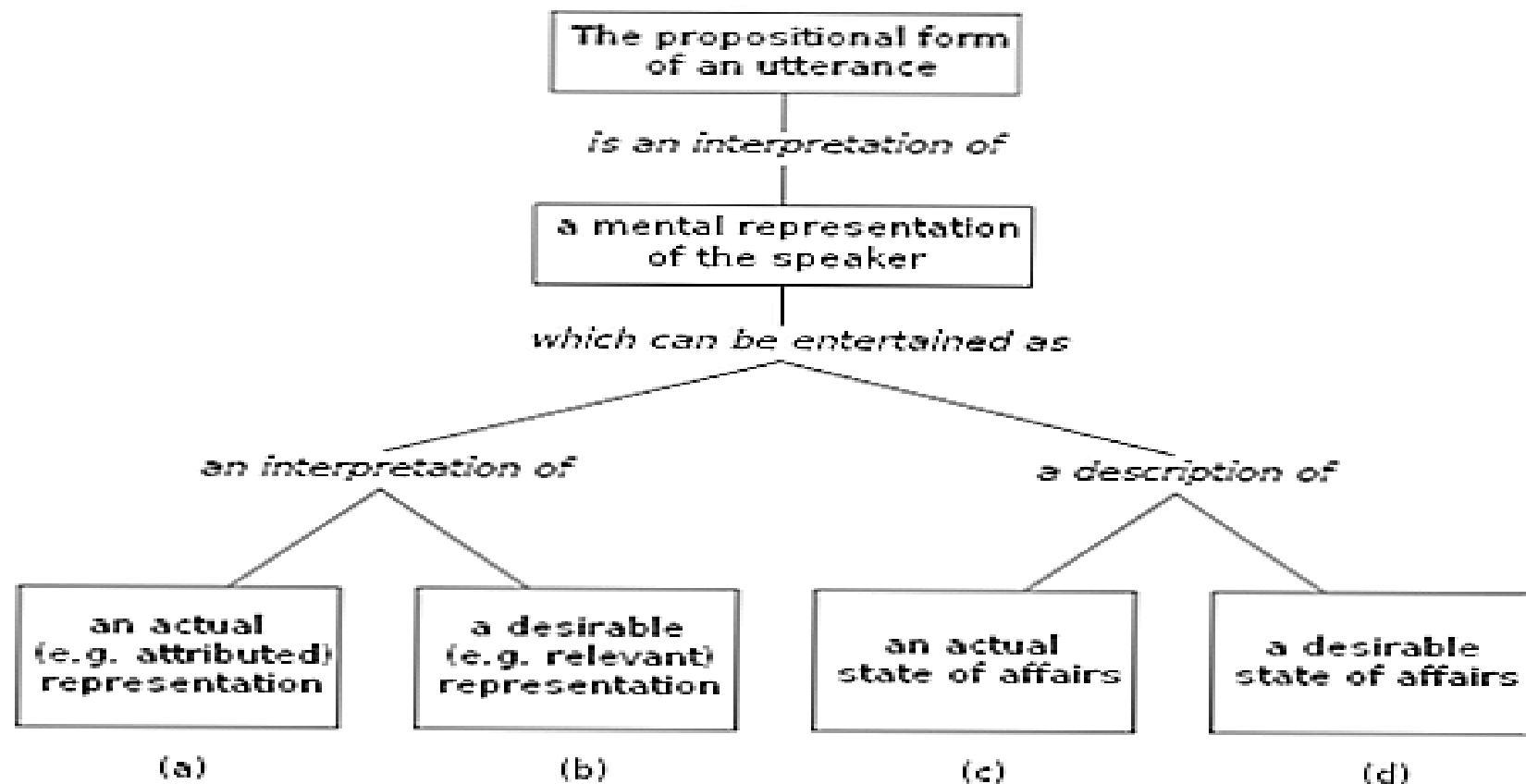
- Relevance theory, as proposed by **Sperber** and **Wilson** (*Relevance: Communication and Cognition*) claims that the search for relevance is a fundamental feature of human communication.
- According to this principle of relevance in communication, an input (a sight, a sound, an utterance, a memory) holds relevance to an individual only when its processing delivers **positive cognitive effects** – i.e. adds to his knowledge on a topic, clarifies a doubt, strengthens, revises or discards his pre-suppositions, and helps him arrive at a true and worthwhile conclusion about the topic.



Contd. ...

- Relevance is a function of **cognitive effect** and **processing effort** of the hearer.
- The degree of relevance is inversely proportional to the processing effort required by the hearer to handle the information in order to arrive at purposeful conclusions.
- Simultaneously, greater the positive cognitive effects an input has on the receiver, greater will be its relevance.
- Thus, owing to the significance of relevance in human communication, the speaker is required to produce stimuli that seems to the audience worthy enough to be processed and yields profitable outcomes.





Contd...

- “to be understood, and to make his audience think or act according to what is to be understood” (Sperber et al., 2010, p.364).

A speaker who intends an utterance to be interpreted in a particular way must also expect the hearer to be able to supply a context which allows that interpretation to be recovered. A mismatch between the context envisaged by the speaker and the one actually used by the hearer may result in a misunderstanding. (Sperber & Wilson, 1995, p.16)

*Ostensive-
inferential
Communication*

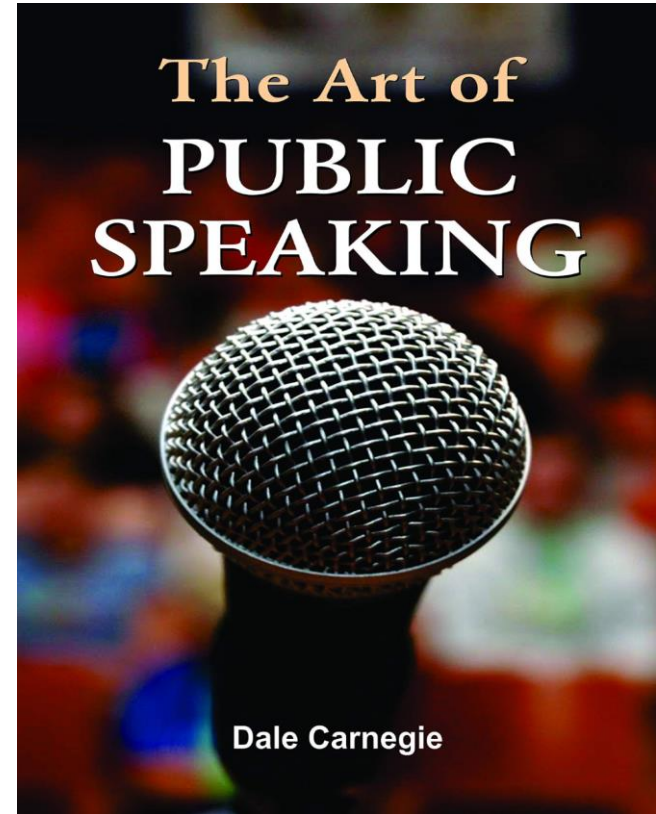
*Explicature
Implicature*

Eloquence: A Survival Skill

- Eloquence has sustained its significance as a highly prized skill globally as well as perennially.
- Humans revel in their higher pedestal among all other life forms owing to their rationale and sophisticated system of communication.
- Surveys establish the fact that we spend approximately 75 % of our conscious time in some form of communicative activity - i.e. LSRW, out of which oral communication or speaking in public forms a major chunk.
- The art of responsible speech communication - either as rhetoric, art, or behavioural science - plays a crucial role as an agent of social recognition in the modern pluralistic society.



- There has been a perpetual rise in the establishment of communication departments offering courses and training in public speaking in colleges, universities and professional organizations across the world.
- **Elwood Murray** sums up the significance of eloquence defining, speech as *“a tool of social adjustment which reflects the efficient personality.”*



An Imperative Need

- Public Speaking as a skill has popularly been associated with people of renown and civic or political import - for example, leaders, social activists, preachers, politicians and media personnels.
- Nevertheless, we are faced with numerous situations of public speaking in our everyday life, and we hear the phrase echoing in our ears **“Now, it’s your turn to speak”**.
- This skill therefore becomes an indispensable art to be harnessed for growth and success in all the realms - personal, professional, civic and the digital.



Public Speaking Adds Perks to the Personality

- **Boosts Confidence** - Public Speaking helps to significantly boost one's confidence by overcoming the fears that are associated with it. It also adds to the self-worth to the speaker as it provides recognition and acceptance of his/her ideas by the audience.
- **Critical Thinking** - Preparing and conducting public speeches calls for an exercise to the critical thinking faculty of the brain. Curating the speech for the audience, adding relevance to the message, organizing the thought in a coherent manner - all of it requires careful critical thinking.



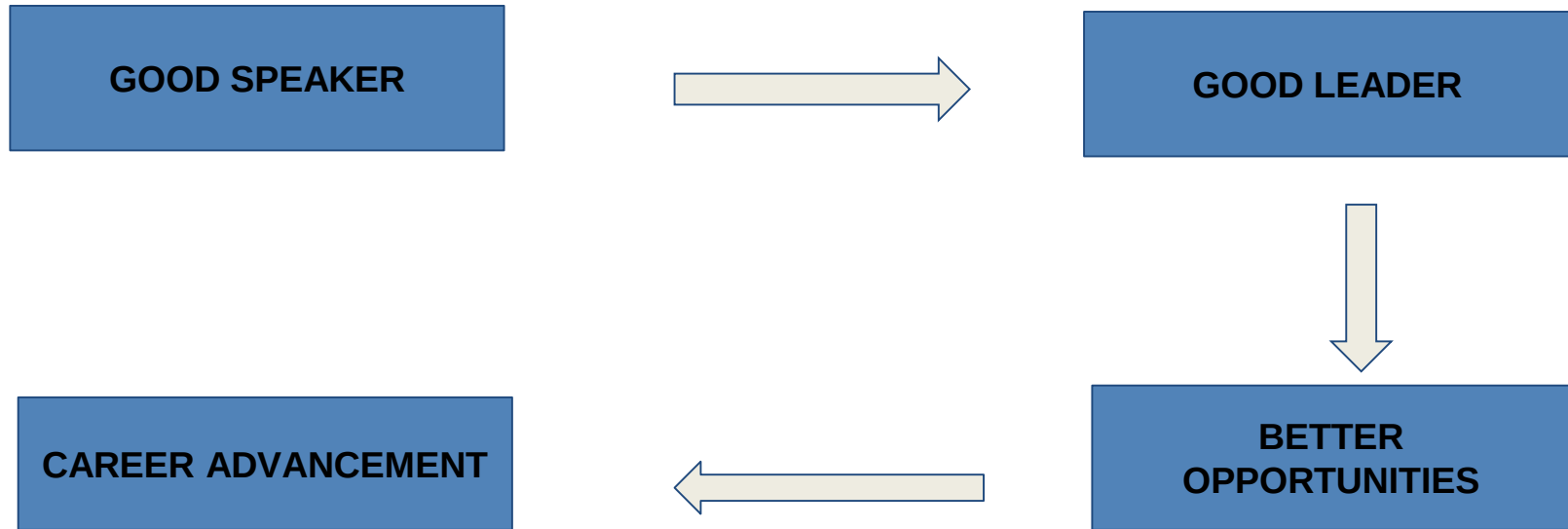
- **Improves Communication Skills** – One’s oratory performance hones both verbal as well as non-verbal communication skills of the speaker. It expands the vocabulary, improvises the manner of articulation, and thus moulds one into a fluent and immaculate speaker. It develops the temperament of becoming a better listener, to be able to calmly tolerate opposing views and defend one’s own.
 - **Personal Development** - Mastering the art of public speaking adds a remarkable flair to the personality of the speaker.
- ❑ *“Nothing in life is more important than the ability to communicate effectively.” (U.S. President, Gerald Ford)*

Public Speaking as a Professional Need

- ❑ Public speaking is a vital skill that bears an enormous impact on success in the professional sphere.
- **Carve a Niche** - Being a good speaker enables one to stand out at the workspace with confidence and to showcase the skills when others avoid such opportunities out of fear of public speaking.
- **Expand Professional Network** - Public speaking offers an array of opportunities to build up advantageous social connections and business contacts via conferences, meetings and other such forums.
- **Career Advancement** - The expertise of eloquence in the workspace is directly proportional to one's professional growth. Public Speaking skills helps to outshine others while exhibiting creativity, leadership, critical thinking and expertise.



- **Leadership Skills** - Speaking in public gives the power to persuade an audience towards an idea or a cause, thereby, promoting leadership qualities.



Most Important Skills for Graduates



Source: <https://www.aacu.org/sites/default/files/files/LEAP/2018EmployerResearchReport.pdf>



Public Speaking has been ranked first among the personal qualities of college graduates sought by employers across various public and private institutions.



A Tool for Social Change

- ❖ **Credibility** - The speaker arouses the passion of the audience by buying credibility for himself through his powerful speech delivery.
- ❖ **Speedy Broadcast** - In comparison to other tools of social media or print media, public speaking enables a faster communication of ideas and a more emphatic delivery of message.
- ❖ **Persuasive Appeal** - Of all the communicative avenues, speaking happens to be the most convincing and compelling force in order to drive a serious change. The message appears livelier when one campaigns for the cause to a live audience via public speaking.



Public Speaking: A Media Tool

In the contemporary digital world, mass media emerges as the giant of public communication. Public Speaking is being constructively used as a media tool in the digital world.

Informative Tool	Persuasive Tool	Entertainment Tool
Public Speaking is instrumental in disseminating knowledge - both academic and professional. Examples: Lectures, Talk-Shows, Ted Talks.	Public Speaking is remarkable in generating and influencing public opinion. Examples: Formal Speeches, Political Debates, BBC Interviews.	Public Speaking is often used as a tool for entertainment of the audience. Examples: Stand-up Comedies, Poetry Recitation .



The Credo of Responsible Oration

- In the wake of the enormous significance accorded to the skill of Public Speaking in personal, social and professional spheres, one needs to cultivate an attitude of being a responsible speaker.
- The fundamental ***Right to Speech*** (Article 19_Constitution of India) implicitly entails the fundamental duty of being an enlightened practitioner of the art of rhetoric in a democratic society:



- To accept the role of well-informed, unprejudiced, judicious articulators
- To express tolerance, respect for feedback, caution with language, precision, and ethics in public speaking
- To defend the speech rights of the opponents in case of a disagreement/debate
- To enjoy the liberty of speech with an acute sense of responsibility



“He who wants to persuade should put his trust not in the right argument, but in the right word. The power of sound has always been greater than the power of sense.”

Joseph Conrad

Thank You



Works Consulted

- ❖ Carnegie, Dale. *The Dale Carnegie Course in Effective Speaking*. New York: The Dale Carnegie and Associates, 2010. Print.
- ❖ Lucas, Stephen, Lazaros Simeon, and Juanita Wattam. *The Art of Public Speaking*. Toronto: McGraw-Hill Ryerson, 2008. Print.
- ❖ Ross, Raymond S. *Speech Communication Fundamentals and Practice*. New Jersey: Prentice-Hall, Inc., 1977. Print.
- ❖ Sperber, D., & Wilson, D. *Relevance: Communication and Cognition* (p. 168). Blackwell Publishers. 1995
- ❖ Zarefsky, David. *Public Speaking: Strategies for Success*. Boston: Allyn & Bacon, 2011. Print.

